

VCF 9.1.x

Upgrade Readiness Checklist

Five gates. Named owners. Evidence before execution.

A companion to “Before You Upgrade to VCF 9.1.x: Five Readiness Gates.” Use this worksheet to assemble a reviewable readiness packet for your exact environment.[1]

SCOPE Planning and review aid—not an executable upgrade runbook or a Broadcom support determination. Revalidate technical requirements against current documentation for the exact source and target builds.

Change record

Field	Record
Organization / environment	
Change ID / evidence repository	
Source release / intended target build	
Scope / domains / deferred work	
Planned window / time zone	
Change owner / technical approver	

Gate review at a glance

Gate	Owner	Status	Evidence / review date
1 Supported path			
2 Network and DNS			
3 Owned sequence			
4 Recovery and Day-2			
5 Automation			

How to complete this worksheet

Use Not assessed / In progress / Blocked / Pass. Leave boxes unchecked until evidence is recorded. Document any item-level N/A with a reason and reviewer; do not silently skip a gate.

For each completed item, record an evidence ID or attachment/link and a checked date. Keep passwords, tokens, and other secrets in the approved secret store—not in this packet.

A lab rehearsal is useful process evidence, not proof that the production environment is ready.[1]

Owner, status, stop-condition, approval, and evidence-index fields are worksheet controls added to the source article; they are not quoted vendor requirements.

GATE 1 / Prove the upgrade path

Decide against exact component builds, not a generic VCF version label.[1]

Change ID: _____ Target build: _____

Owner: _____ Reviewer / date: _____

Status: Not assessed / In progress / Blocked / Pass

- ☐ Record every deployed component and domain, with exact source versions/builds and intended target versions/builds.[1]
- ☐ Validate the supported upgrade path and interoperability for each applicable source/target combination; save dated references.[1]
- ☐ Check forward-only release-date validation for the entire source bill of materials, including vCenter and ESX.[1]
- ☐ Use the VCF Upgrade Planning Tool to structure the phases, then validate the exported plan against documentation for the exact target.[1]
- ☐ Resolve every unsupported combination, unknown build, and applicable conditional component before passing this gate.[1]

Inventory / compatibility evidence — attach the full inventory if needed

Component / domain	Source version + build	Target version + build	Dated path / interop evidence ID
VCF / domains			
VCF Operations / cloud proxy			
SDDC Manager			
NSX Managers / Edges			
vCenter / ESX			
Other applicable components			

Evidence references / checked dates: _____

PASS WHEN The documented path is supported for this specific environment, and the reviewer can explain why.[1]

STOP / HOLD: Unknown or unsupported source/target combination; missing build inventory; unresolved interoperability or release-date conflict.

Additional stop conditions / unresolved blockers:

GATE 2 / Validate the management network

Review the runtime pool, service addresses, DNS, and internal CIDR as one allocation.[1]

Change ID: _____ Target build: _____

Owner: _____ Reviewer / date: _____

Status: Not assessed / In progress / Blocked / Pass

- ☐ Reserve the services runtime pool: the article identifies a 12-address minimum (/28) and recommends 30 (/27). Verify the exact target requirements.[1]
- ☐ Reserve up to five unique, unused service IPs outside that pool but on the same network, one FQDN for each role below. The Identity Broker FQDN applies only if you do not already have an appliance-mode broker deployed.[1]
- ☐ Verify DNS resolution and naming: lowercase FQDNs and no .local. Test your own domain in the deployment validation step before you commit to it.[1]
- ☐ Check internal-CIDR overlap against management, VM, and pool networks. Document the selected range and routing evidence.[1]
- ☐ Match the allocation syntax, deployment network, and UI/API workflow to the exact target build; have the network owner review the worksheet.[1]

Version checkpoints from the article: 9.1.0.0–9.1.0.300 uses strict CIDR in the UI; 9.1.0.400 adds exclusions/lists; 9.1.1 adds UI selection of deployment network/internal CIDR. Default internal range: 198.18.0.0/15; documented alternatives: 240.0.0.0/15 and 250.0.0.0/15. Revalidate before use.[1]

Network/VLAN + mask/gateway: _____

Runtime pool / exclusions / capacity: _____

Internal CIDR + overlap proof / UI or API method: _____

Service addresses — separate from the runtime pool

Service role	FQDN	Reserved IP	DNS evidence ID
Services runtime			
Fleet component			
Instance component			
Identity Broker (if not already deployed)			
License Server			

Evidence references / checked dates: _____

PASS WHEN The exact-target network worksheet is reviewed, including DNS, pool ranges, service addresses, and internal CIDR.[1]

STOP / HOLD: Address reuse/exhaustion, unresolved DNS, overlapping networks, or an allocation/workflow unsupported by the target build.

Additional stop conditions / unresolved blockers:

GATE 3 / Turn the sequence into owned work

The worksheet supports the vendor sequence; it does not replace that runbook.[1]

Change ID: _____ Target build: _____

Owner: _____ Reviewer / date: _____

Status: Not assessed / In progress / Blocked / Pass

- ☐ Attach the ordered upgrade procedure for the exact source/target. Include mandatory fleet-level and management-domain work, plus any deferred Day-N workload-domain work.[1]
- ☐ Assign an executor and verifier, entry criteria, exit evidence, and a stop condition to every phase; include all conditional components.[1]
- ☐ Before VCF Operations: assess appliance-mode Identity Broker 9.0.x placement. Redeploy first if it uses an NSX overlay or a different network/datastore from the planned management services.[1]
- ☐ Confirm a cloud proxy exists in the instance hosting VCF Operations for the management-services deployment dependency.[1]
- ☐ Plan the certificate/password-management gap after Operations reaches 9.1 until Automation, Identity Broker, Logs, and Networks are each upgraded. Schedule required rotations before or after that gap.[1]
- ☐ Capture evidence for inventory, certificate, and service-account migration and automatic fleet-management-appliance decommission during the Operations upgrade.[1]

Phase ownership — extend in the attached runbook; rows are not a prescribed order

Phase / component	Executor / verifier	Entry criteria	Exit evidence	Stop condition

Evidence references / checked dates: _____

PASS WHEN Every phase has named ownership and an observable exit condition; every applicable conditional component is accounted for.[1]

STOP / HOLD: Missing owner/dependency, unhandled Identity Broker placement, an unplanned rotation conflict, or absent phase-exit evidence.

Additional stop conditions / unresolved blockers:

GATE 4 / Prove recovery and the Day-2 handoff

Backups must connect to a recovery owner and a product-specific procedure.[1]

Change ID: _____ Target build: _____

Owner: _____ Reviewer / date: _____

Status: Not assessed / In progress / Blocked / Pass

- ☐ Confirm recent native file-based vCenter backups, SFTP backup targets for SDDC Manager and VCF Operations, and NSX Manager backup evidence.[1]
- ☐ Record backup identity/time, location/access evidence, recovery owner, and the applicable restore procedure. A snapshot-only plan does not satisfy this gate.[1]
- ☐ Document recovery-validation evidence and outstanding gaps; distinguish a completed restore exercise from a procedure review. Do not mark untested recovery as tested.
- ☐ Hand off the management-services restrictions: no moves to another resource pool or VM folder; Storage vMotion of these nodes to another datastore is unsupported.[1]
- ☐ Verify Storage DRS behavior for the actual deployment build. The article notes it is disabled by default starting with VCF 9.1 EP2; do not assume older deployments have that setting.[1]
- ☐ Confirm the operations team will use VCF Operations for lifecycle work after the upgrade, rather than relying on the deprecated SDDC Manager UI.[1]

Recovery evidence — keep credentials out of this worksheet

Component	Backup ID / time / location reference	Restore procedure / validation evidence	Recovery owner
vCenter appliance(s)			
SDDC Manager			
VC Operations			
NSX Managers			

Day-2 handoff recipient / date: _____

Recovery exercise or review date / result / gaps:

Evidence references / checked dates: _____

PASS WHEN Recovery responsibility is assigned and evidence-backed; the operating team acknowledges the placement and lifecycle rules.[1]

STOP / HOLD: Missing/inaccessible backup, unknown restore owner or procedure, undisclosed recovery gap, or unacknowledged Day-2 restrictions.

Additional stop conditions / unresolved blockers:

GATE 5 / Validate the automation workstation

Automation needs its own evidence; infrastructure success does not prove script compatibility.[1]

Change ID: _____ Target build: _____

Owner: _____ Reviewer / date: _____

Status: Not assessed / In progress / Blocked / Pass

- ☐ Inventory the hosts and identities that actually run scheduled jobs—not just the interactive administration shell.[1]
- ☐ Record PowerCLI, SDK, language-runtime, and PowerShell versions and verify support for the chosen target release.[1]
- ☐ Test the selected module/SDK/runtime combination in a separate environment before changing the scheduled runner.[1]
- ☐ Run representative authentication, certificate/trust, and inventory workflows read-only first; retain results.[1]
- ☐ Identify and test only explicitly approved write operations; retain their approval and result evidence separately.[1]
- ☐ Assign owners and evidence for scheduled scripts, monitoring, and post-upgrade automation validation.[1]

For the article's 9.1.1 toolchain: Python SDK 9.1.1.0 supports Python 3.10–3.14; Java SDK requires Java 17+; PowerCLI 9.1.1 requires PowerShell Core 7.0.13+, adds Python 3.14 for Image Builder, and drops Image Builder Python 3.7–3.9. These are compatibility boundaries, not recommended minimum deployments. Recheck the exact tool release.[1]

Scheduled-runner and workflow validation

Runner / job / identity	Module / SDK / runtime versions	Read-only test + evidence	Approved write test + evidence

Test environment / test date: _____

Automation support owner / escalation reference:

Evidence references / checked dates: _____

PASS WHEN Operational automation has recorded validation results on its actual execution stack, independent of the platform-upgrade status.[1]

STOP / HOLD: Unsupported runtime/module combination, unresolved authentication/trust failure, missing representative test evidence, or unapproved write operations.

Additional stop conditions / unresolved blockers:

Execution authorization & closeout

Readiness approval and post-upgrade acceptance are separate decisions. Do not pre-mark validation as passed.

Before the window — go / no-go

- ☐ All five gates have a reviewed Pass; required evidence is accessible and current.
- ☐ All scope changes, dependencies, item-level N/A decisions, and residual risks have explicit disposition.
- ☐ The maintenance window, communications, recovery owner, and escalation contacts are confirmed.

Decision: ☐ GO ☐ NO-GO / HOLD

Approver / role / approval date and time: _____

Approval reference / conditions / unresolved issues:

Readiness packet attachment index [1]

Attachment	Evidence ID / link
Exact source/target inventory and dated path/interoperability references	
Owned phase sequence, exit evidence, and stop conditions	
Network/DNS/certificate/address-allocation evidence	
Backup/recovery evidence and Day-2 handoff	
Automation results and post-upgrade acceptance plan	

After the upgrade — record actual validation [1]

Check	Verifier	Result / evidence ID / date
Authentication and identity access		
Licensing / entitlement state		
Monitoring / collection / alerting		
Lifecycle operations / component health		
Scheduled automation / representative workflows		
Day-2 operating handoff accepted		

Result values: Not run / Pass / Fail / Blocked / N/A with reviewed reason.

Actual target builds / deviations / remaining actions:

Closeout owner / acceptance reference / date:

Sources and scope

[1] <https://ithinkvirtual.com/posts/vcf-9-1-upgrade-readiness-five-gates> — Before You Upgrade to VCF 9.1.x: Five Readiness Gates | iThinkVirtual

Adapted from the published iThinkVirtual article, retrieved September 30, 2026. This worksheet is not an independent re-audit of vendor documentation. Recheck version-specific conditions before execution.